treaties of 1921 and 1931 would prevent an arms race that could result in great power conflict in Asia between the navies of Japan, the United States, and Great Britain, primarily.[19] The creeping Sino-Japanese military conflict, begun in Manchuria in September 1931, did not spur further US preparedness in case a wider war broke out, nor did it cause a coalition of Western colonial nations to consider collective defense of their territories in Asia from what was an increasingly belligerent Japanese policy.

The Japanese attacks throughout Asia on December 8 (December 7, in Hawaii), 1941, were a direct bid for hegemony in the western Pacific. Alone, they might not have spurred any truly strategic thought on the part of the United States, but coming in conjunction with the Nazi threat to Europe, they generated the first serious, sustained strategic planning for Asia in the context of US global interests. That America had no grand strategy prior to World War II, let alone a strategy for Asia, was recognized by contemporaries. The columnist and foreign policy analyst Walter Lippmann, for example, excoriated the very lack of US grand strategy prior to and during the war, reiterating what he called the "common principle" of genuine foreign policy—namely, that a nation must balance its commitments with its power. Without adequate resources, a state cannot uphold its commitments, and thus its foreign policy will remain out of balance. In particular, Lippmann argued, Washington left its frontiers unguarded, its armaments unprepared, and its alliances unfounded.[20] This "gap" was particularly noticeable in eastern Asia, where America's Philippine possessions were all but undefended.

As for the overarching US strategy required in a global environment, contemporary observers were equally clear. Lippmann argued that the continental limits of the United States did not equal the country's defensive frontiers.[21] This mirrored the wartime arguments of geopolitical scholar Nicholas Spykman, who stated that the goal of US foreign policy must be to preserve the balance of power in Europe and Asia as the first line of defense for the United States. Spykman argued that America's unique geographical advantage of being protected by two